

Ceremonial Use of Entheogens in Puerto Rico: What 100 Survey Responses Told Us

A plain-language summary for the general public and media. This document translates a detailed statistical report into everyday language. It describes what a survey of 100 adults in Puerto Rico found about their experiences with ceremonial plant medicines (ayahuasca, psilocybin mushrooms, and others). It is not a scientific paper — for the full technical analysis, contact the researchers for specifics.

A note before you read on: Most of this report is about people's positive experiences, but one section (Section 6, "Safety") discusses uncomfortable topics, including unwanted physical contact and mental health crises during ceremonies. We include this honestly and carefully because it matters for community safety — not to alarm anyone or to suggest these events are common.

1. What this study was and wasn't

A research team from the University of Puerto Rico (Río Piedras and Medical Sciences campuses), the PR Institute for Psychedelic Science, and Colectivo Psicodélico de PR built an anonymous online survey to learn about ceremonial use of entheogens — substances like ayahuasca and psilocybin mushrooms used in spiritual or healing ceremonies — among adults 21 and older in Puerto Rico.

Some important context on what kind of study this is:

- **100 people responded.** This was the team's target, and they reached it.
- **This is not a poll that represents "all of Puerto Rico."** People found the survey through word of mouth and community networks (a "snowball" sample), not through random selection. That means the results describe *the people who took this survey*, not the entheogen-using population of Puerto Rico as a whole. No numbers in this report should be read as "X% of Puerto Ricans do this."
- **No validated survey like this existed before.** The research team built the questionnaire from scratch, since there was no existing, tested instrument for this specific topic in Puerto Rico.
- Everything here is descriptive — it tells us what this group of respondents reported, not what *causes* what.

2. Who took the survey

Out of 100 people who started the survey, 87 made it far enough to be asked whether they had participated in or led a ceremony. Of those 87:

- **65** had only participated in ceremonies (not led any)
- **8** had only led ceremonies (facilitators)
- **7** had done both — participated and facilitated
- **14** said "no" to both, meaning they hadn't taken part in a ceremony (these responses are kept because they help us understand who considered the survey but didn't have ceremony experience)
- **13** left the survey before answering this question at all

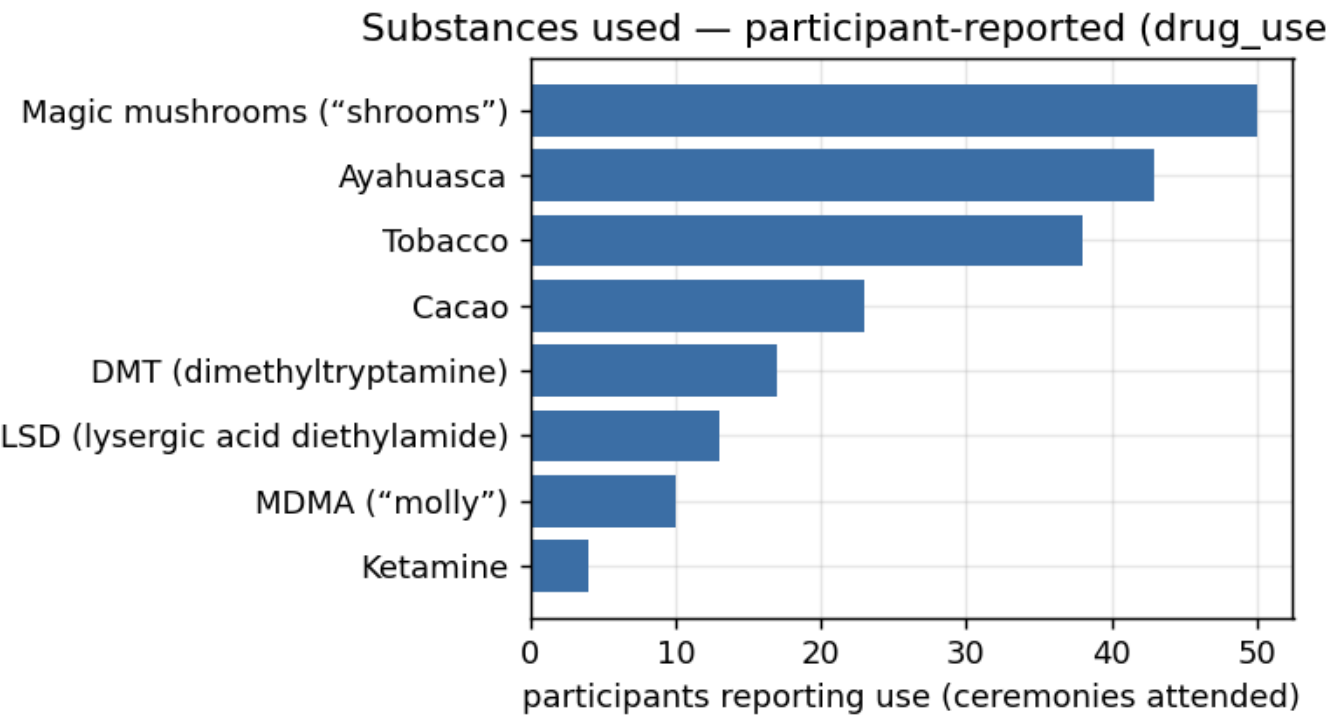
So the "core" group used in most of the analysis below is about **72 participants** and **8 facilitators** (with 7 people counted in both groups, since their experiences overlapped).

Who were they, roughly?

- **Age:** average around 42 years old, ranging from 21 to 75.
- **Gender:** about 48% women, 45% men, 5% non-binary, and a small number who preferred not to say.
- **Education:** a highly educated group — about 48% had a bachelor's degree and 26% had a master's degree.
- **Financial situation:** most described themselves as comfortable (57%) or getting by with some difficulty (30%); 9% said they often couldn't cover basic needs.
- **Where they live:** the large majority (95%) live in Puerto Rico; a few lived in the U.S. mainland or Spain.

What this means: this is a well-educated, financially stable, PR-based group of adults in their 40s on average. It's a useful window into this particular community, but it likely does not reflect the full diversity of everyone in Puerto Rico who has ever taken part in a ceremony.

3. What ceremonies looked like



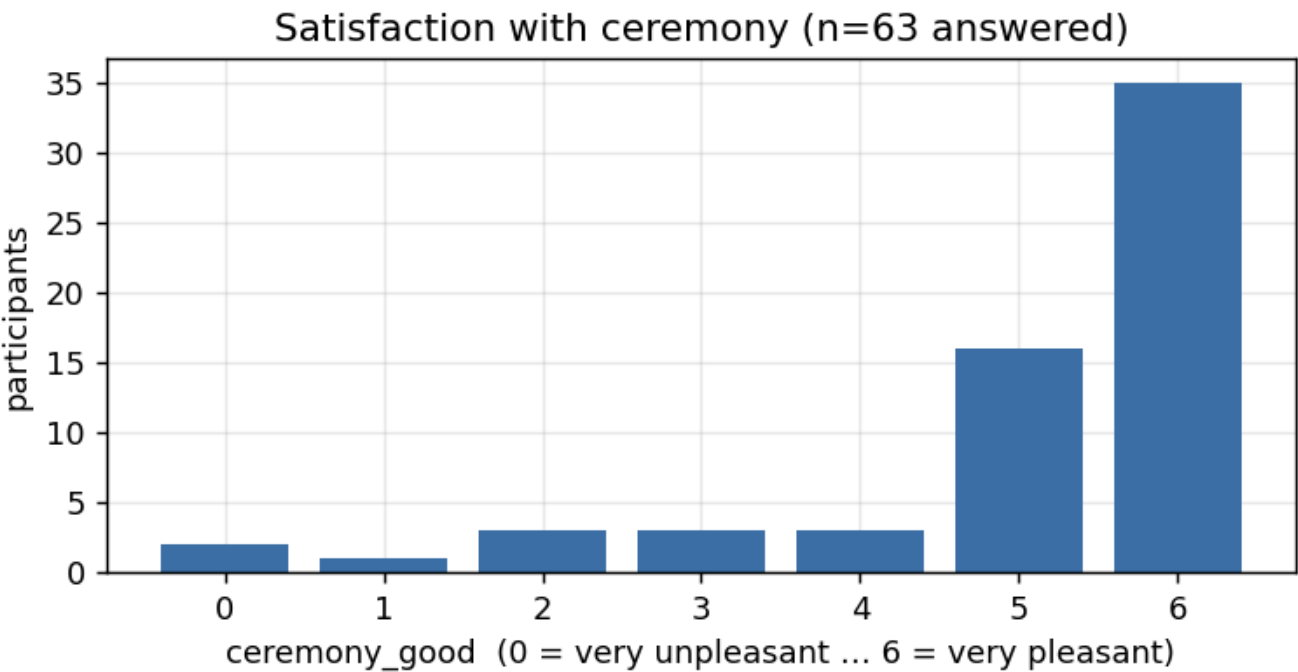
Among participants, the two most common substances were **psilocybin (magic) mushrooms** and **ayahuasca**, with a smaller number of people reporting other substances (cacao, DMT, tobacco, LSD, and others), each too small a group to report on individually with confidence.

A few other things about how ceremonies happened:

- Most people had been to a **handful of ceremonies in their lifetime** (the typical person had been to about 6), but only about **1 ceremony in the past year** — this is not, for most people, a frequent or constant practice.
- **About 45% of participants hadn't been to a ceremony in over a year** at the time of the survey.
- The most common setting was **outdoors, in a natural place** like a forest, beach, or mountain (about 55%), followed by a private home (22%) and retreat centers (13%).
- Most ceremonies were **single, one-time events** (74%) rather than multi-day retreats or series (20%).

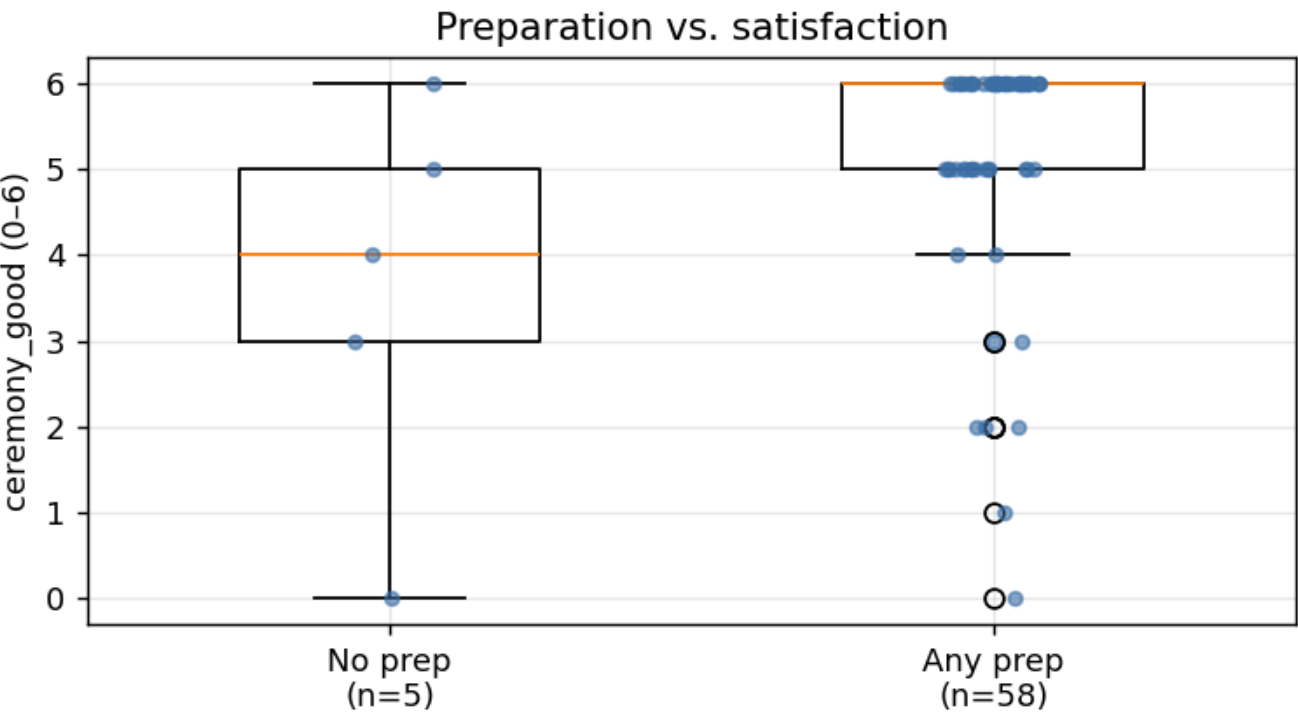
- Ceremony length varied a lot — evenly split between a few hours, an overnight experience, and multi-day retreats.

4. How people felt about their ceremonies



Participants were asked to rate how good their most recent ceremony experience was, on a scale of 0 to 6. The results were **strongly positive**: most people rated their experience a 5 or 6, and very few rated it poorly.

Did preparing beforehand make a difference?



People who did *some kind of preparation* before their ceremony (dietary changes, guidance from the facilitator, setting an intention, etc.) tended to report higher satisfaction than the small number who did no

preparation at all. This pattern held up when we looked at it more carefully, but the group who did *no* preparation was very small (only 5 people), so this finding should be treated as an **early, suggestive signal** rather than a settled conclusion. More data from future respondents would help confirm it.

Did trusting the facilitator matter?

Yes — people who said they knew about their facilitator's background and training ahead of time reported meaningfully **higher trust** in that facilitator. This is one of the more solid patterns in the data. However, it did not clearly translate into differences in how *safe* or *comfortable* people felt moment-to-moment during the ceremony — those two things (trust and in-the-moment comfort) didn't move together as strongly as we might expect.

Did the substance matter?

We compared satisfaction between people who used ayahuasca versus mushrooms most recently. Ayahuasca ceremonies scored very slightly lower on average, but the difference was small enough that we can't confidently say it's a real difference rather than chance.

5. Who were the facilitators?

Only **8 people** in the survey identified as facilitators (people who lead ceremonies for others), so everything in this section should be read as a small, early snapshot — not a reliable statistical picture of "how facilitators in Puerto Rico operate."

With that caveat:

- Most facilitators said they learned through **personal experience and self-study** (75%) or **mentorship/apprenticeship** (about half), rather than formal certification or academic training — none reported formal certifications or academic courses.
- Most (86%) said they typically hold ceremonies **outdoors, in nature**.
- Facilitators reported doing some form of **screening or intake conversation** before ceremonies — most said they talk with participants about their medical history and medications beforehand.
- When something difficult happens during a ceremony, the most common response facilitators described was using **music or sound** to help guide the person through it, followed by grounding techniques (breathing, sensory focus) and calming words.

6. Safety: what we learned about difficult and harmful experiences

This section discusses unwanted physical contact and mental health crises. We report this plainly, because understanding it matters for community safety, but ask readers to keep in mind the very small numbers involved — this is not a survey designed or powered to produce a precise safety statistic, and every number here comes from a small group of people.

Unwanted physical contact. Participants were asked whether they experienced non-consensual physical contact during a ceremony. Among the 67 participants who answered:

- **61 said no**
- **5 said yes** (about 7% of those who answered, though the true rate could reasonably be anywhere from about 3% to 16% given the small sample)
- A handful said they weren't sure

This is a real finding that deserves attention: a small but non-trivial share of participants in this sample reported unwanted contact. We looked at whether knowing more about a facilitator's background beforehand, or being asked screening questions, was linked to a lower chance of this happening. The patterns we saw were suggestive of a protective effect, but with so few "yes" responses in total, we cannot say this with confidence — it needs to be studied with a larger sample.

Facilitator-witnessed crises. Separately, the small group of facilitators (7 of the 8 answered this question) were asked whether they had ever witnessed a participant go through a serious crisis during a ceremony they led — including things like panic attacks or suicidal thoughts. **We can confirm that this has happened and was witnessed by facilitators in this sample.** Because the facilitator group is so small, we are not able to report exact numbers for each type of crisis without making it possible to identify individual people, so those specific counts are withheld. This finding is one of the clearest arguments in this whole report for doing more research — specifically, surveying a much larger group of facilitators — since safety planning and training depend on understanding how often, and in what form, these crises occur.

Bottom line on safety: nothing in this data lets us say precisely how common these problems are in the broader ceremony-going community. But the survey confirms that both unwanted contact and serious psychological crises do occur, and that facilitator training practices (which are almost entirely self-taught and informal in this sample) deserve further study and possibly more structured support.

7. Legal knowledge and worry

Entheogens exist in a complicated legal space in Puerto Rico. We asked participants how much they understood about the legal status of these substances, and how worried they were about legal consequences.

We looked at whether legal knowledge or legal worry was connected to three things: whether someone talked to a doctor or therapist about their ceremony use, whether they were screened by their facilitator, and whether they experienced unwanted contact. Across the board, **we did not find strong or consistent links** between legal knowledge/worry and these outcomes. One weak signal — that people who talked to a health professional beforehand also reported somewhat more legal worry about their most recent ceremony — showed up, but it didn't hold up once we accounted for the number of comparisons we ran, so it should be treated as noise rather than a real pattern for now.

8. In people's own words

Participants and facilitators answered several open-ended questions in their own words — 285 answers in total, mostly written in Spanish, with some in English. These haven't been fully analyzed yet (that's a task for the research team's next phase), but a first pass at common words and themes shows recurring ideas around:

- **Legality and regulation** of entheogen use
- **The presence of medical or mental-health framing** in how people describe their experience
- **How facilitators are vetted** or chosen
- **Education** — wanting more public understanding of these practices
- Common words used again and again: *dieta* (diet/preparation), *ceremonia*, *salud mental* (mental health), *medicina*, *experiencia*, *espiritual*, *educación*

This open-text data is a rich resource that the research team plans to analyze in more depth to understand these themes in participants' own voices.

9. How trustworthy is this data?

We checked the data for quality problems before drawing any conclusions:

- **Attention checks:** questions built into the survey to catch people who weren't reading carefully. Only **2 of 100 respondents** answered any of these incorrectly — a very low rate, suggesting most people engaged carefully with the survey.
- **Possible duplicate entries:** we checked for people who might have submitted the survey more than once. A small number of overlapping entries (2 pairs) were flagged for the research team to review manually; none were automatically removed, since we can't be certain they're true duplicates versus coincidence.

Overall, the data quality checks came back reassuring — this appears to be a carefully collected dataset with only minor, flagged concerns.

10. What should happen next

Based on everything above, a few clear next steps stand out:

1. **Survey more facilitators.** With only 8 in this sample, we cannot say anything statistically solid about facilitator practices or the frequency of crises during ceremonies. This is the single biggest gap.
2. **Follow up on the safety findings.** The rate of unwanted contact (about 7%, though uncertain) and confirmed reports of serious psychological crises deserve dedicated, larger-scale research — and possibly community conversations about facilitator training and screening standards.
3. **Treat the "preparation helps satisfaction" finding as promising but unconfirmed,** and design a future study that could test it more rigorously with a larger no-preparation group.
4. **Analyze the open-text answers in depth** — this is where much of the emotional and cultural texture of people's experiences lives, and it's currently only lightly explored.

This summary was prepared from the full technical report produced for this study. Numbers, comparisons, and caveats here are simplified for a general audience; anyone wanting exact statistics, confidence intervals, or methodology details should consult the full report.